Pakistan corresponds well with a strategy of proxy balancing.[39] The relationship with Pakistan has since grown into “arguably the most stable and durable element of China’s foreign relations.”[40]

In this period, China viewed India as a strategic rival able to destabilise China’s Western frontier, leading to a relatively confrontational Chinese policy. Furthermore, there were few platforms for dialogue and cooperation between them. The People’s Republic of China was not a member of the United Nations, regional mechanisms had yet to be established, and economic cooperation between China and India was almost non-existent.

China’s rapprochement with the United States and Sino–Indian relations

Four major events made 1971 a watershed year in Chinese foreign policy and its relationship with India. First of all, after a decade of international isolation in the aftermath of the Sino–Soviet split, Henry Kissinger’s secret visit to Beijing set China on the course toward normalising its relationship with the United States. Second, in November 1971, the People’s Republic replaced the Republic of China (Taiwan) as a member of the United Nations and became a veto member of the UN Security Council. These two events greatly enhanced China’s role in international affairs and its position vis-à-vis the Soviet Union and India. However, two other events the same year increased Chinese concerns on its Western frontier. Growing unrest in East Pakistan during the spring of 1971 increased the likelihood of Islamabad losing control of the eastern part of the country and then potentially reducing China’s ability to apply pressure on India